

Mountain People

Both the US and North Vietnam tried to enlist the support of the Montagnards, the indigenous people of South Vietnam's rugged highlands. The Green Berets spent the early part of the war wooing, training, and arming the tribesmen, whom they nicknamed Yards.

◀◀ BEFORE

Collectively called the Montagnards (Mountain People) by the French, the hilltribes of Vietnam yearned for a homeland of their own.

HISTORICAL ENMITY

Vietnamese distrust of the Montagnards predated French colonialism. The Montagnards, who were labeled *moi* (savages) by the Vietnamese, sided with France in the [First Indochina War](#) in the hope of being rewarded with an autonomous homeland. However, the [Geneva Accords](#) made no provisions for them, and they continued to face discrimination during the Diem regime.

It was the CIA, not the Diem government, that came up with the idea of enlisting the Montagnards as allies in the fight against the Viet Cong. In late 1961, Colonel Gilbert B. Layton, a Marine officer on loan to the CIA in Saigon, and David Nuttle, an International Voluntary Services official working with the Rhade tribe in the Central Highlands, jointly conceived what they called the Civilian Irregular Defense Group (CIDG) program as a means of blocking Viet Cong infiltration. William E. Colby, the CIA station chief in Saigon, backed the scheme.

Pilot project

They chose Buon Enao, just to the northeast of Buon Ma Thuot, in the heart of Rhade country, to test the plan, and in November 1961, Nuttle, a CIA officer, and a Special Forces medical specialist visited the village to confer with the local elders. After more than two weeks of negotiations, the elders agreed to collaborate with the Americans, and in February 1962, a Green Beret team arrived in Buon Enao to train the village defenders. They planned to extend their operations to neighboring villages once a secure base had been established.

By the summer, five Green Beret A-Detachments were operating in the Rhade tribal area. Camps were established to serve as bases for the so-called trail watchers—specially formed and trained groups of Montagnards tasked with reconnaissance on South Vietnam's jungle frontier, including along the Ho Chi Minh Trail. Khe Sanh, in the Bru tribal area, became operational in July 1962, and Dak To and Dak Pek, both in the Sedang tribal area, were set up in August.